Chapter 2

The Teop language documentation and the content of this volume

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1 The historical background of the Teop language documentation

The Teop language documentation project started with a fieldwork methods course which the native speaker Ruth Saovana Spriggs and I gave at the Australian National University in 1992. In 1994 we got a grant from the Australian Research Council that enabled Saovana to travel home and do audio-recorded interviews about the culture of her people and their personal histories. When I moved to Kiel in Germany in 1995, Saovana and I continued our work per email and in person when she visited me in Kiel for three months in 1995 and two months in 1999.

From 2000 to 2007 our project was generously funded by the Dokumentation-Bedrohter-Sprachen Programm (DobeS) of the Volkswagen Foundation, so that we could do further fieldwork, pay the Teop team members in Bougainville for their full time or part time work, and employ research assistants in Kiel and Canberra.[1] Saovana was a team member until March 2005 when she left the project to concentrate on her PhD thesis. In 2009 the project was funded for 16 months by the German Research Foundation, and afterwards by private resources. In 2014, I visited Bougainville for the last time.

[1]See https://dobes.mpi.nl/projects/teop/team/.



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The organization of our work in Bougainville was considerably influenced by the so-called Bougainville Conflict, a civil war which had its roots in the people's sufferings from colonialism and started in 1988. The most important dates of the island's history are listed in Table 1.

Table 1: Some dates of the history of the Bougainville Island. See Sack (2015), Nelson (2015), Mahaka et al. (2014), Parker (2010), and Purupuru et al. (2014).

DATE	DESCRIPTION
1885–1914	German colonial rule
1901–1902	First mission of the Catholic Marists
1914–1920	Australian military administration
1920–1942	Australian administration granted by the League of Nations
1920	Start of the Methodist mission
1924	Start of the Seventh-day Adventist mission
1942–1945	2nd World War
1942	Invasion by the Japanese army
1943	Invasion by the Allied Forces
1945–1975	Australian administration
1972	Beginning of mining at the Paguna copper and goal mine (Panguna Mine)
1975	Independence of Papua New Guinea (PNG)
1988	Begin of the Bougainville Conflict between the landowners of Panguna and the Bougainville Copper Ltd, which escalated into an armed conflict
1990–1997	Absence of an effective government body, development of anarchy
1997	Truce, deployment of peace monitoring groups from New Zealand
1998	Permanent ceasefire, peace monitoring groups from Australia
2001	Peace agreement

The Bougainville Conflict was a civil war that arose between the Papua New Guinea Security Forces (PNG SF) and Bougainvillean people who formed the Bougainville Revolutionary Army (BRA) to fight against the disastrous environmental effects of the Panguna Mine, the exploitation of the indigenous landowners, and the immigration of 15,000–20,000 non-Bougainvillean workers.[2] When

[2]Regan (2001)

in 1989 the mine closed and in 1990 the PNGDF (Papua New Guinea Defense Force) imposed a blockade on Bougainville Island, all immigrants left the island and all kinds of trade were stopped, so that "subsistence gardening became the sole means of survival" (Havini 2004: 4). Bougainvillean people who had lived and worked in other provinces had to return to their villages in Bougainville. The Teop people were not directly involved in the battles, but they suffered from the blockade, unjust treatment by both parties, and attacks by criminal gangs. After the peace agreement in 2001, this insecure and economically demanding situation continued for many years.

2 The collaborative fieldwork

In 2000 Saovana and I travelled for a short visit to Bougainville where she introduced me to some Teop leaders and to Ruth Sima Rigamu who invited me to stay with her in the village Hiovabon during future fieldwork visits. After this visit, Saovana went to Bougainville by herself in 2001 and 2003 to do more interviews, whereas I did twelve fieldwork trips by myself between 2003 and 2014, and one in 2006 together with the student assistant Yvonne Thiesen. Since Saovana and I did not do fieldwork together in Bougainville, this section only describes the work of the team I worked with in Hiovabon.

The social and economic consequences of the Bougainville Conflict had a considerable impact on the organization of our fieldwork and the subsequent processing of the data collected:

1. Because of the lack of any trade stores in the Teop area and the need for subsistence gardening and fishing, the average duration of our fieldwork was only four weeks.

2. For security reasons, I was not allowed to bring a computer with me until 2008, so that all transcriptions of recordings, translations and fieldnotes had to be written by hand, then typed up and printed in Kiel, reviewed and corrected by hand during the next fieldwork, brought back to Kiel to be incorporated in the Teop Language Corpus as ELAN[3] and PDF files, and

[3]ELAN is an annotation tool for audio and video recordings developed by the Max-Planck Institute für Psycholinguistics (https://archive.mpi.nl/tla/elan), see also Barth & Schnell (2022: 102-105).

in the Toolbox[4] lexical data base, and eventually brought back or sent to the Teop people as books printed in Germany (Mosel et al. 2007b; Mahaka et al. 2010).

3. Because of the Teops' bad experiences with foreigners, neither I nor the Teop team members could ask the speakers to sign "a participant consent form" (Meakins et al. 2018: 37–38). I also refrained from asking personal questions about clan membership, social status, or education, so that the metadata of the Teop Language Corpus (TLC) documents do not conform to the ideals of digital archives (Meakins et al. 2018: 76).

During my first two field trips in 2003 my host Ruth Sima Rigamu and the teacher and graphic artist Neville Vitahi introduced me to seven Teop villages and helped me to explain and discuss our documentation project. Simultaneously they organized our local research team, so that we could do the first recordings and transcriptions of spontaneously spoken folktales, stories about the Teop history, and descriptions of traditional customs and practices. By the end of our second fieldwork in 2003, it became clear that the transcriptions needed to be supplemented by edited versions, because the transcriptions are neither suitable as reading materials for school children nor a pleasure to read for any readers other than linguists (Mosel 2004, 2024). But for linguists the edited texts and their oral originals show what kind of lexical and grammatical changes the editors made when they transformed oral texts into written ones and thus created a new register in a language which previously lacked written folk tales, historical narratives, and descriptions of the environment, artefacts and crafts (Mosel 2015).

In March 2004, the Teop team – Enoch Horai Magum, Joice Maion, Naphtali Maion, Ruth Sima Rigamu and Neville Vitahi – decided to record more folktales, and transcribe and edit them for a primary school reader, but also to continue the recording of texts about the history and the traditional culture of the Teop people, because elderly people were keen to transmit their knowledge to future generations. From 2005 onwards the team members felt confident in writing Teop texts without doing recordings and transcriptions. The edited and written texts were proof-read by the teachers Jubilee Kamai and Ondria Tavagaga. In

[4]Toolbox is a data management and analysis tool for field linguists that has been developed by SIL (https://software.sil.org/toolbox/), see also Meakins et al. (2018: 177). The Teop Toolbox lexical data base has been organized and cared for by Marcia Schwartz from 2000 to 2007, whereas Jessika Reinig and Yvonne Thiesen worked as research assistants on the annotation of the Teop texts in ELAN from 2000–2003 and 2000–2007, respectively. The Teop phonology was analyzed and described by Alexander Radtke (2005).



Figure 1: Launch of the school book on house building

the following years we published a school book with 40 folktales (Mosel et al. 2007b), a small book on house building (Mahaka et al. 2010), a bilingual history book (Mosel 2014a), and much later the Multifunctional Teop-English Dictionary, abbr. MTED, in which short encyclopedic texts were included as "examples" with translations, see Mosel (2019). The Teop texts of this volume are of three types:

1. originally oral texts whose speaker figures as the first author, whereas the editor figures as the second author;

2. texts that were written and edited in team work; the first author is the one who wrote the first version, whereas the second author did most of the editorial work;

3. texts that have been written and edited by the same author.

The translations were always done in teamwork. They were either done by the Teop author or the editor, and then explained to me, or I did the translation with the help of the author, the editor or my host Ruth Sima Rigamu, but as the final editor of this volume I carry the responsibility for all translations.

From a corpus linguistic perspective, the Teop Language Corpus (TLC), and in particular this text collection is a so-called opportunistic corpus without a specified sampling frame (Mosel 2018: 250).

3 The content and the structure of this volume

The Teop texts and their English translations are presented in two forms. Part II to Part V present the chapters on plants, house building, canoes and fishing techniques as bilingual texts in two columns with photographs and drawings. Each of these four parts is introduced by a short chapter which summarizes its content and gives some background information with references to the anthropological literature and to related dictionary entries in the MTED.

Part VI contains the same texts and their translations, but in addition provides a morphological word-by-word segmentation of the Teop text with a linguistic glossing of each segment. If the free English translation is markedly different from its Teop source with respect to its syntax and phraseology, a literal translation is added in footnotes, so that the Teop text, its morphological segmentation, glossing, and free translation are presented in four lines, see below:

Three words of line (5:148)			
Teop text	*teo vuri nahu*		
Word division	te=o	vuri	nahu
Glossing	PREP=ART3.SG	time	cook
Free translation	'when they cook them'[5]		

If you have the PDF-version of this book and find a quotation like "see (5:148)", you can simply click this reference and then find it in its context. The first number links to the chapter in Parts II–V, while the second number links to the glossed text in Part VI.

4 Bibliographic data of the text collection

For each chapter of this volume, Table 2 below lists the labels of the text in the Teop Language Corpus (TLC) and the examples in the Multifunctional Teop-English Dictionary (MTED), two dates, and a word count for each text. If the chapter represents the edited version (E) of an oral text, the first date refers to the recording (wav), and in the case of a written text (W) it refers to the production

[5] lit. 'at the time (of) cook(ing)'

of the manuscript (ms). The second date refers to the production of the ELAN text in both cases.

Most chapters consist of a text that is the same as the one in the TLC. The exceptions are Chapters 13, 14, and 23 which are excerpts from descriptions that Ruth Sima Rigamu wrote for the MTED.

Table 2: The texts in this collection.

CHAP	TITLE	AUTHORS	LABEL	DATES	WORDS
PART II – Plants used for artefacts					
5	*O overe* – The coconut palm	Joyce Maion	Joy_17W	2009/2011	1,552
6	*O atovo* – The sago palm	Ruth Sima Rigamu and Joyce Maion	Sii_Joy_03W	2009/2012	491
7	*O sinivi* – The canoe tree (Blackboard Tree)	Joyce Maion	Joy_24W	2011/2012	190
8	*O baneo visoas* – The young breadfruit tree	Ruth Sima Rigamu and Joyce Maion	Sii_Joy_05W	2012/2013	202
9	*O poosusu* – The sea poison tree	Joyce Maion	Joy_20W	2011/2012	86
10	*Koverau, kururu, koopu* – Three kinds of bamboo	Ruth Sima Rigamu and Joyce Maion	Sii_40W	2012/2012	392
11	*Kara naono* – Vines, aerial roots, fibres and strings	Ruth Sima Rigamu	Sii_24W	2009/2011	747
12	*Kara roge* – Hibiscus fibres for making strings	Joyce Maion	Joy_18W	2009/2011	127
13	*Karaa* – Pandanus	Sima Rigamu	Sii_17W_191-211	2009/2009	225
14	*Taovu* – The giant pandanus and the hood	Ruth Sima Rigamu and Joyce Maion	Sii_41W_31-44	2012/2014	141

CHAP	TITLE	AUTHORS	LABEL	DATES	WORDS
PART III – Building houses from plant materials					
16	*A sinoo na inu* – The frame of the house	Enoch H. Magum	Eno_05W	2005/2008	393
17	*A kiu vaa teo atovo* – The work on the sago palm thatch	Enoch H. Magum	Eno_02W	2005/2008	705
18	*O kovuaka* – The top thatch sheet	Enoch H. Magum	Eno_07W	2005/2008	147
19	*A takinima* – The woven bamboo wall	Enoch H. Magum	Eno_03W	2005/2008	445
20	*O paranda* – The floor	Enoch H. Magum	Eno_04W	2005/2008	380
PART IV – Dugout canoes with outriggers					
22	*O sinivi suuna* – The indigenous canoe	Mark Tahi and Enoch H. Magum	Tah_02E(Eno)	2003/2006	357
23	*O aga* – The outrigger float	Sima Rigamu	Sii_17W; tier 031-044	2008/2009	103
24	*O sinivi potee* – The imported canoe called *potee*	Paul Morekevan and Enoch H. Magum	Mor_04E(Eno)	2003/2009	612

CHAP	TITLE	AUTHORS	LABEL	DATES	WORDS
PART V – Fishing techniques					
26	*A goroto* – The turtle	Naphtali Maion and Ondria Tavagaga	Naph_01W	2008/2009	579
27	*Kave goroto* – The turtle net	Mark Tahi and Enoch H. Magum	Eno_08W	2003/2009	477
28	*A vaahoa kave goroto* – The launching of the turtle net	Enoch H. Magum	Eno_09W	2008/2009	213
29	*Kakavei* – The bamboo frame net	Naphtali Maion	Naph_03W	2008/2009	624
30	*Varigomo* – A kind of net fishing	Enoch H. Magum	Eno_12W	2006/2009	295
31	*Seige* – Fishing with a net on two mangrove poles	Enoch H. Magum	Eno_14W	2006/2009	241
32	*Tanaa* – Fishing in a group during low tide	Helen K, Magum and Shalom Magum	Hel_08E(Sha)	2009/2010	272
33	*Vavaaiku* – Angling with a swinging bait	Enoch H. Magum and Shalom Magum	Eno_15W	2009/2012	204
34	*Vavaatoa* – Kite fishing	Naphtali Maion	Naph_02W	2008/2009	238
35	*Vagana haopi* – Catching wrasses by hand	Helen K, Magum and Shalom Magum	Hel_09E(Sha)	2009/2010	195
36	*Paka suva* – Fish poisoning leaves	Helen K, Magum, Shalom Magum and Joyce Maion	Hel_14E(Sha)	2009/2011	214
37	*Ana suva* – Fish poisoning roots	Helen K, Magum, Shalom Magum and Joyce Maion	Hel_15E(Sha)	2009/2011	201
38	*Suvasuva kokobus* – Fish poisoning with sea cucumbers	Helen K, Magum, Shalom Magum and Joyce Maion	Hel_16E(Sha)	2009/2011	161
39	*Hovuhovu iobo* – Digging sea-sausages	Helen K. Magum and Shalom Magum	Hel_07E(Sha)	2009/2010	303
Total					**11,512**